

CORE FORMULA

Event cue -> light acknowledgement -> interpretation question -> silence -> follow their read. -> That was [brief neutral acknowledgement]. What did you make of it? -> When [event] happened, what was your read on it? -> No need to have a neat answer - what is your read so far? -> What is your interpretation of what happened there?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

After they have described an event but before they have interpreted it, ask one clean meaning-making question: "What did you make of it?"

BEST FOR

- Someone has described a meeting, date, result, message, review, argument, or social moment
- The facts are mostly clear, but their interpretation is not yet clear
- You want to avoid giving advice too early
- You want to understand their judgement, takeaway, suspicion, or uncertainty
- The conversation is at risk of becoming a flat sequence of fact questions
- A professional review, coaching chat, learning debrief, or relationship check-in where their read matters
- You need to choose your next response based on what they believe the event meant

PHRASE BANK

Quick / default · Everyday one-liners

- "What did you make of it?"
- "What was your read on it?"
- "How did you interpret that?"
- "What did you take from it?"
- "What do you think was going on there?"
- "What stood out as the meaning of it?"
- "What did that signal to you?"
- "What is your sense of it now?"
- "What is your read on what it might mean?"

Soft / low-pressure · Protects uncertainty

- "No need for a polished answer - what is your read so far?"
- "If you had to guess, what did you make of it?"
- "What did you take from it, if anything?"
- "Maybe it is too soon to know, but what sense are you making of it?"
- "What are you leaning toward as the explanation?"
- "What sense are you making of it so far?"

Social / casual · After ambiguous stories

- "That is a strange one. What did you make of it?"
- "What was your vibe on that?"
- "Did it feel like a good sign, a weird sign, or too early to tell?"
- "What did you think it meant?"
- "What did you make of the night overall?"

Professional / work · Reviews and debriefs

- "What is your read on the meeting?"
- "What did you take away from that feedback?"
- "How are you interpreting the client's response?"
- "What do you think that result is telling us?"
- "What is the signal beneath the noise here?"
- "What is your interpretation of what happened there?"

Digital / text · Before you reply to a message

- "What did you make of that message?"
- "How are you reading their reply?"
- "What do you think they meant by that?"
- "What is your read before we decide how to respond?"
- "Interesting. What did you make of that?"

Conflict / repair · Invites impact without defending

- "When I said that, what did you make of it?"
- "What was your read on my tone there?"
- "How did that land for you? What did it seem to mean?"
- "I may have misread the moment. What did you make of it?"
- "How did that come across to you?"

Release add-ons · Take the pressure off

- "No pressure to analyse it."
- "Could be nothing; I was just curious how you read it."
- "We can stay with the facts if that is easier."
- "If you are not sure yet, that is a complete answer."
- "Too early to tell is a complete answer."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: They were obviously being passive-aggressive. What do you think?
Better: What did you make of it?
Best: That sounds like a mixed signal. What did you make of it - or is it too early to tell?
2. Weak: So what does that actually mean?
Better: What do you think it means?
Best: What is your read on what it might mean?
3. Weak: Were they trying to undermine you?
Better: How did you interpret it?
Best: When they said that in the meeting, what was your read?
4. Weak: Why would they even do that?
Better: What did you make of that?
Best: What did you make of that - careless, intentional, or hard to tell?

DECISION TREE

If They described an event, you do not yet know their read, and the moment is calm

Ask one clean meaning-making question, then leave the silence.

"What did you make of it?"

If They have not described an event yet, or you still lack basic facts

Hold the question; listen or ask what happened first.

"What happened next?"

If You already know their interpretation

Skip to a summary check, meaning reflection, or next-step question instead.

"So your read is... have I got that right?"

If The moment is unsafe, distressed, or high-pressure

Support, validate, or ask what they need before any analysis.

"What would help most right now?"

If They are unsure or say "I don't know"

Normalise it and let uncertainty stand as the answer.

"Too early to tell is completely fine."

If They resist, tense up, or change topic

Recover and release the question straight away.

"No pressure - we can leave it."

SCENARIOS

A friend describes an odd interaction

They gave facts but no interpretation; reflect their read, not your theory. — "That is a strange one. What did you make of it?"

A colleague describes a mixed meeting

The signal is ambiguous; summary-check before you offer advice. — "What was your read on the meeting?"

A partner says a comment bothered them

They may need interpretation and care; listen, validate impact, repair. — "When I said that, what did you make of it?"

A client sends a vague response

The team is guessing meaning; separate evidence from inference. — "Before we reply, what do you make of their response?"

A digital message feels unclear

People over-read tone; add uncertainty afterwards so nobody spirals. — "How are you reading that message?"

A learning debrief

They described what happened; turn their insight into one experiment. — "What do you think that result is telling you?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- They are in acute distress and need support, safety, or action first
- The event is traumatic and the question would feel like a demand to process before they are ready
- You still need basic facts before any interpretation makes sense
- They have already told you exactly what they made of it
- The question would sound sceptical, accusatory, or like they must defend themselves
- You are mining for leverage, gossip, blame, or agreement
- Physical safety or an immediate emergency takes priority

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the gap

Notice three moments where someone describes an event but not what they made of it. Just notice the gap; say nothing yet.

Day 2 — Write the compact move

Take those three events and write the minimum viable question for each: "What did you make of it?" Keep it to one line.

Day 3 — Three registers

For one event, write a direct, a soft, and a contextual version - e.g. "What did you make of it?", "What is your read so far, if any?", "When they said that, what did you take from it?"

Day 4 — Strip the loaded answer

Rewrite three leading questions ("They were pushing you out, right?") into clean, non-leading reads that carry none of your verdict.

Day 5 — Add the recovery

After each question, write one release phrase - "No pressure to analyse it" or "Too early to tell is fine" - so the ask is always easy to decline.

Day 6 — Ask and leave the silence

In one real conversation, ask a single meaning-making question and do not fill the pause or add your interpretation until they have answered.

Day 7 — Anchor, ask, reflect

Run the full chain once: a brief comment, the question, then reflect their read back in your own words before any advice.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask after enough context, or too early?
- Did my tone sound curious rather than sceptical?
- Did I keep my own interpretation until after theirs?
- Did I let "I don't know yet" stand as a valid answer?
- Did I follow their read instead of steering them to mine?
- Did I notice whether the question created space or pressure - and recover if it landed heavy?